



## TRINIDAD CARIBBEAN

## A Tropical Taste of Trinidad

In the Caribbean Sea's southernmost reaches, Trinidad forms a vibrant multicultural crossroads between South America and the West Indies. A sun-drenched, palm-scattered multilingual isle, Trinidad's richly diverse ethnicity mixes Indian, African, Amerindian, and European ancestry in a cultural mix that has resulted in fantastic multiethnic cooking styles and exotic food traditions.



Claimed by Columbus for Spain in the 15th century, Trinidad soon acquired African slaves in addition to its native Amerindian population in a bid by the Spanish to create a flourishing plantation colony. In the early 18th century, French planters arrived to cultivate sugar and cocoa, followed shortly afterward by the British, who took control of the island in 1802. Spanish-speaking laborers from Venezuela and black laborers from the United States also settled in Trinidad in the 19th century, as did 150,000 workers from India's northern tip, Portuguese-speaking sailors from Madeira, and Cantonese farmhands from China. Today, the influences of Trinidad's colorful racial makeup have permeated every aspect of the island, including its cuisine.

The food of Trinidad is deliciously rich in exotic flavors, mixing the robust spices of India with the fresh local fruits, nuts, and vegetables of the Caribbean. From flavorsome Creole dishes of pot-stewed chicken with red beans and plantains to delicate Cantonese-style stir-fried vegetables, Trinidadian foods are well seasoned, and each one is a dish to savor. Yet it is the humble roti (or rosti) flatbreads that characterize "Trini" kitchens across the island, from the buttery

paratha, yellow lentil *dhalpourie*, and potato *aloo pourie* to the perennial favorite – *dosti*. *Dosti* is made using two disks of roti dough rolled out one on top of the other to form a "sandwiched" double layer; they are said to be like two friends – *dosti* – meeting, hence the name. The bread is cooked on a lightly greased hot *tawah* (baking stone) and served alongside dishes such as thick soups of curried chickpeas and potato dishes spiced with turmeric and fenugreek. It often accompanies a traditional curried duck recipe, where the birds are cooked in large iron cauldrons over an open flame on the banks of the Ortoire River.

Much has changed since Columbus first set foot on Trinidad, but this small island still epitomizes the Caribbean idyll. Almost 20 sandy stretches punctuate its coastline, and its natural attractions have been protected: there are wildlife sanctuaries, bird breeding centers, and eco-conservation areas. In the capital, Port of Spain, crowded street markets bustle among fine colonial mansions set around the capital's 260-acre (105-hectare) Queen's Park Savannah. All Trinidadians relish social gatherings and have made "the Savannah" and its surrounding zoo, botanical gardens, plazas, and cricket grounds central meeting points for the convivial consumption of feather-light, flaky *dosti*.

### Three Days in Trinidad

Trinidad's 90-by-40 mile (145-by-65-km) landscape rolls out mountain peaks, beaches, streams, rivers, coconut palms, tropical flora, and rustling sugar cane crops.

**DAY ONE** Spot scarlet ibis at the 40-sq-mile (100-sq-km) **Caroni Bird Sanctuary**, Trinidad's most prized ecological site and a vast butterfly-rich swampland interlaced with waterways trimmed by blue, mauve, and white lilies.

**DAY TWO** Discover picturesque sands at **Maracas Bay**, Trinidad's most stunning soft white-sand beach. As the sun goes down, join local night owls to revel in calypso music. **Port of Spain's** vibrant nightlife scene boasts numerous musical venues that offer a riot of color, dance, costume, and pulsating beats.

**DAY THREE** Spend the morning exploring **Pitch Lake**, a mysterious, otherworldly watery expanse dating back millions of years, discovered in 1595 by Sir Walter Raleigh. After lunch visit Port of Spain's "**Magnificent Seven**" – a collection of fine historical landmark buildings built on mudflats once tangled by knots of mangroves.

### Essentials

#### GETTING THERE

Trinidad's **Piarco International Airport** lies 20 miles (32 km) southeast of the capital. Use **cars, taxis, and minibus taxis** to get around.

#### WHERE TO STAY

**Orchard View Guest House** (inexpensive) is a friendly family-run B&B located east of the airport in lush countryside. (868) 313 0459  
**Laguna Mar Resort** (moderate) is an oceanfront retreat for nature-lovers. [www.lagunamar.com](http://www.lagunamar.com)  
**Hyatt Regency Trinidad** (expensive) offers luxury in Port of Spain. [www.trinidad.hyatt.com](http://www.trinidad.hyatt.com)

#### TOURIST INFORMATION

[www.gotrinidadandtobago.com](http://www.gotrinidadandtobago.com)

